

Society & Social Issues

59 words · Society & Social Issues

NOUNS

poverty

the state of being extremely poor

Child poverty has risen sharply in the last decade.

crime

an illegal act punishable by law

Petty crime tends to increase during economic downturns.

rights

legal or moral entitlements that every person should have

Everyone has the right to free speech.

protest

a public demonstration expressing disapproval of something

Thousands took to the streets in protest against the new law.

welfare

government financial support for people in need

She relied on welfare payments after losing her job.

refugee

a person forced to leave their country due to war, persecution, or disaster

The camp was home to over ten thousand refugees.

corruption

dishonest or illegal behaviour by people in positions of power

Corruption within the police force undermined public trust.

equality

the state of being equal in rights, status, and opportunities

Gender equality remains a major issue in many workplaces.

community

a group of people living in the same area or sharing common interests

The local community came together to support the families affected.

discrimination

unfair treatment of a person or group based on prejudice

Discrimination on the basis of age is illegal in most countries.

inequality

an unfair difference in wealth, opportunity, or treatment between groups

Income inequality has widened dramatically since the 1980s.

prejudice

an unreasonable negative opinion formed without knowledge or thought

Racial prejudice is still deeply embedded in many institutions.

stereotype

an oversimplified and fixed idea about a type of person or group

The film relied on lazy stereotypes rather than real characters.

ADJECTIVES

homeless

without a permanent place to live

The charity provides meals for homeless people every evening.

fair

treating people equally and without bias

The system isn't fair. It favours those who can afford lawyers.

privileged

having advantages that most people do not have

He grew up in a privileged household and attended private school.

disenfranchised

deprived of rights or power, especially the right to vote

Many young people feel disenfranchised by the political system.

vulnerable

at risk of harm or in need of special care or protection

Elderly people living alone are particularly vulnerable.

marginalised

treated as unimportant and pushed to the edge of society

Marginalised communities are often the last to benefit from economic growth.

systemic

relating to or affecting an entire system rather than individual parts

Systemic racism cannot be solved by individual acts of kindness alone.

grassroots

driven by ordinary people at a local level rather than by leaders

The movement started as a grassroots campaign and grew into a national force.

VERBS

ban

to officially prohibit something

The government has banned single-use plastic bags.

campaign

to work in an organised way towards a social or political goal

She has campaigned for disability rights for over twenty years.

advocate

to publicly support or recommend a cause or policy

She advocates for prison reform and rehabilitation over punishment.

vote

to formally indicate a choice in an election or decision

She voted for the first time when she turned eighteen.

tackle

to make a determined effort to deal with a problem

The government has pledged to tackle homelessness.

PHRASAL VERBS

speak out

to publicly express your opinion, especially about injustice

More people are speaking out against workplace harassment.

stand up for

to defend or support a person, belief, or principle

She always stands up for what she believes in, even when it's unpopular.

look out for

to take care of or protect someone

People looking out for each other, especially the more vulnerable members.

bring about

to cause something to happen, especially change

The protests brought about a change in government policy.

phase out

to gradually stop using or providing something

The subsidy is being phased out over the next three years.

crack down on

to take strong action to stop or punish something

Police have cracked down on drug dealing in the area.

come together

to unite or cooperate as a group

More so since the pandemic, actually. People really came together.

COLLOCATIONS

break the law

to do something illegal

He broke the law and faced the consequences.

a moral dilemma

a situation in which every available option involves some kind of wrongdoing or harm

Whether to report her best friend's mistake put her in a real moral dilemma.

a hot topic

a subject that is widely discussed and often controversial

Immigration has always been a hot topic in election campaigns.

the gap between rich and poor

the difference in wealth between the richest and poorest in a society, a common collocation in this topic

The gap between rich and poor has widened massively.

bring about change

to cause change to happen

Sometimes. The civil rights movement proves protests can bring about real change.

make a difference

to have a meaningful positive effect on a situation

Even small actions can make a difference.

raise awareness

to help people understand an issue they may not know about

The campaign raised awareness of mental health in schools.

the greater good

the overall benefit of a group or society, even if it means an individual loses out

The villagers agreed to the new road for the greater good, even though it cut through several gardens.

a fair chance

an equal opportunity

Not really. Where you're born still matters more than it should.

IDIOMS

turn a blind eye

to deliberately ignore something wrong or illegal

The authorities turned a blind eye to the pollution for years.

bridge the gap

to reduce the difference between two groups or things

Education is the best way to bridge the gap between rich and poor.

a level playing field

a situation where everyone has an equal chance
All we're asking for is a level playing field.

bend the rules

to apply an official requirement loosely rather than strictly, usually to help someone
The examiner bent the rules slightly and gave her ten extra minutes.

sit on the fence

to avoid taking a clear side in a disagreement or decision
Stop sitting on the fence and tell us what you actually think.

a double-edged sword

something that has both positive and negative consequences
Social media is a double-edged sword. It connects and divides.

the lesser of two evils

the less harmful choice between two unwelcome options
Neither policy solved the problem; we just voted for the lesser of two evils.

SET PHRASES

that said

used to introduce a point that contrasts with what was just conceded
I take your point. That said, I'd hate to lose it completely.

on balance

a conclusion reached after weighing up everything relevant
On balance, though, I'd keep it as a personal choice.

MODERN SLANG

woke

aware of and actively attentive to social and racial justice issues
The term woke has become politically charged in recent years.

the tip of the iceberg

a small visible part of a much larger hidden problem
The cases we hear about are just the tip of the iceberg.

a grey area

a situation with no clear rule or obvious right answer
Whether it's cheating to get an AI to help with homework is still a bit of a grey area.

sweep under the carpet

to hide a problem or scandal rather than deal with it
The abuse was swept under the carpet for decades.

a dying breed

a type of person, skill, or tradition that is becoming increasingly rare
Craftsmen who can restore a piece like this by hand are a dying breed.

hypothetically speaking

used to introduce an imagined, not a real, situation
Hypothetically speaking, if a robot could genuinely feel empathy, should it have rights?

cancel culture

the practice of publicly rejecting or boycotting someone for offensive behaviour
Cancel culture is one of the most divisive topics in modern debate.

old-school

having traditional attitudes or methods, often said
with approval

*She's old-school about manners: she still writes
thank-you cards by hand.*